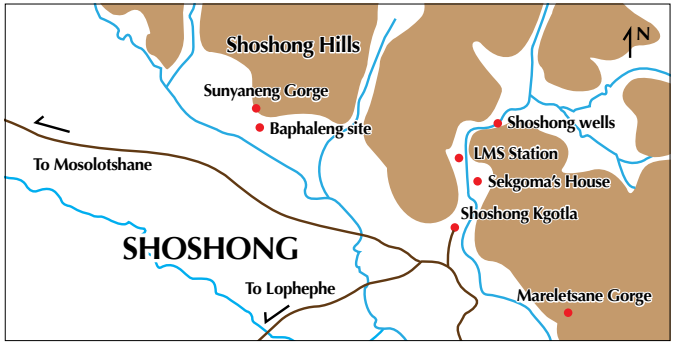
Natural Heritage

Shoshong Hills are the most outstanding physical feature in the area. They are dominated by brownish to grey weathered ironstones from the greywacke unit. The rock is made up of minerals such as hornblende, biotite and some minor white grains of plagioclase and quartz. The ironstone rocks constitute numerous packed fractures which form spectacular brick-like formations. Fracturing of these rocks often results in animal track-like features caused by downhill movement of small loose rocks. These are easily mistaken for cattle tracks due to destruction of plants growing on paths of falling rocks.

Old Shoshong is also characterised by acacia bushes. Large stands of monkey thorn trees are a common sight along the banks of the stream running through the site. These plants and others are home to birds, small animals and several species of insects.

Access to Site

The site is easily accessible from the village centre with permission granted at the kgotla. Guided tours of the site are organized from the village kgotla.



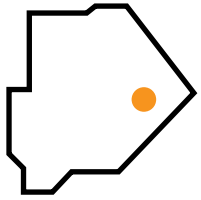
Management of the Site

The Botswana National is working in partnership with the community of Shoshong to ensure the development and management of Old Shoshong. The site has custodians to guide and make your visit worthwhile.





OLD SHOSHONG



Designation: Cultural
Area: approx. 30,000m²
Adoption priorities:
visitor interpretation centre and gatehouse

For further information, contact:
The Archaeology Division, Botswana National Museum
Private Bag 00114 Gaborone, Botswana
Phone: +267 3974616 Fax: +267 3911186 / 3902797

BOTSWANA national museum

ADOPT A MONUMENT
GIVING LIFE TO BOTSWANA'S HERITAGE SITES

SH201511

Cultural Heritage Site

OLD **SHOSHONG**

Prehistory

Shoshong Hills have been home to different groups of people. Late Stone Age hunter gatherers lived in the area about 10,000 years ago. Bantu farmers arrived around 900 AD and occupied hilltops, valleys and some plains. They reared domestic animals such as cattle, sheep, goats and grew crops such as millet, sorghum and cowpeas. The Bantu people lived in permanent villages made of clay, poles and thatched houses. They produced metal tools used for farming such as iron hoes and knives. The remains of these villages are found at Pitsane Hill and Sung in the Shoshong Hills.





Cultural History

The Bantu people were replaced by Bakgalagadi groups during the 16th century. The Bakgalagadi lived in various parts of the Shoshong Hills herding their cattle, growing crops and hunting wild animals. By the 18th century, the area around Shoshong experienced an influx of Tswana groups. The Bakaa moved into the Shoshong Hills and established their village at Phata ya Sebilo. They found a group of Bakhurutshe and drove them out. They then conquered the Baphaleng living west of Shoshong Hills and forced them to subdue to their rule. Around 1790, the Bangwato occupied in the area between Lephephe and Shoshong Hills. In 1849, their leader, Sekgoma I attacked the Bakaa and drove them out of the Shoshong Hills. The Bangwato subsequently established their capital around the gorge in Shoshong. Sekgoma I developed his capital into an important trading town. Khama III took over from Sekgoma I in 1875. Shoshong flourished during the reign of Khama III and became an important stopover for travelers, hunters and missionaries journeying distances to Lake Ngami, Bulozi and Matabeleland.





Shoshong was abandoned in 1889 due to environmental reasons. The town was overpopulated and hosted over 30,000 people who soon depleted resources in the area. A serious drought struck the area, leading to drying up of the stream and wells that were the main source of water. Pastures were exhausted by large herds of cattle which died in large numbers leading to poor hygiene in the town. Khama III was forced to abandon his beloved town to settle on the foot of the Tswapong Hills where Phothophotho gorge would provide abundant water.